THE GAP

MICRO IMMERSION SERIES · DISCIPLINE NO. 03

OCEAN IMMERSION · NORTH SHORE, OAHU, HAWAII

The Ocean.

10 Days on the North Shore.

The ocean doesn't care about your ego. Big wave surfing — or even just learning to be comfortable in powerful surf — is one of the fastest ways to strip performance and find out who you are when something massive is happening and you can't control it.

10	8	Ocean	30ft	$3,200
DAYS	SPOTS	DAILY	WAVES	ALL-IN

No surfing experience required. Comfortable swimming is required. The ocean is the teacher — Mark Healey is the guide. The 10 days will put you in more powerful water than you have ever been in. Voluntarily. With the right tools.

apply@bridgethegap.com

THE PHILOSOPHY

The ocean decides everything.

The North Shore of Oahu is the most famous stretch of coastline in surfing. In the winter months — November through February — it receives the largest swells in the world, generated by storms in the North Pacific and arriving after thousands of miles with nothing to slow them down. Waimea Bay, Eddie Aikau's break, comes alive at 15 feet and has held faces of 40 feet. Pipeline — the Banzai Pipeline — breaks in eight feet of water over a shallow reef so violently that it has ended careers and lives. Sunset Beach runs for a quarter mile and produces waves with the energy of freight trains.

You are not here to surf these waves. You are here to understand the ocean that produces them — to develop enough fluency in big water that you are never helpless in it. That is what Mark Healey teaches: ocean safety, waterman skills, and the physical and mental toolkit for operating in powerful surf. Hold-down training. Reading swells before they arrive. Understanding rip currents — not as things to panic about, but as tools to use. Freediving as a way to extend your comfort window underwater. The North Shore is the classroom because it is the most instructive ocean environment in the world.

What this teaches is specific and transferable: the ability to stay composed when something enormous and uncontrollable is happening, to assess accurately and act decisively rather than freeze, and to develop the kind of confidence that only comes from repeated voluntary exposure to powerful forces. You cannot think your way into that confidence. You have to swim into it.

THE GAP · CORE BELIEF

"The moment a wave holds you down and everything goes dark and the pressure builds and you don't know which way is up — that is the moment you find out whether you have trained your

nervous system or not. The North Shore is where you go to train it."

Every discipline in THE GAP framework is chosen because it teaches something that cannot be learned in a classroom. The ocean teaches a specific kind of composure — the ability to suspend panic in genuine emergencies. That composure, built through repeated deliberate exposure, is one of the most durable things a person can develop.

The Waterman

The concept of the waterman — someone who is comprehensively fluent in the ocean, able to surf, paddle, freedive, read weather, understand currents, and operate safely in conditions that would strand or kill a casual swimmer — has deep roots in Hawaiian culture. Eddie Aikau was a waterman. Mark Healey, who teaches this immersion, is one of the most complete watermen alive.

The waterman approach is not about becoming a professional surfer. It is about developing a complete and functional relationship with the ocean — understanding it, respecting it, and operating inside it with competence rather than fear. The North Shore is where this tradition lives. This is where it gets passed on.

01

Adventure + Adrenaline

Hold-down training in open water. Paddling and swimming in powerful North Shore surf. Waimea Bay. Freediving sessions. The ocean at its most instructive is genuinely powerful — and that is the point. The adrenaline is not manufactured. It is the Pacific Ocean in winter.

02

Travel + Encounter

Live on the North Shore during surf season — the most concentrated gathering of elite ocean athletes in the world. Study Pipeline from shore with Mark. Understand the culture of Hale'iwa and the Hawaiian relationship to the ocean. This is not a beach holiday. It is an immersion into one of the

03

Service + Giving Back

Day 9: ocean conservation and reef cleanup with a local Hawaiian organization. The North Shore's reef systems are under pressure from climate change and human impact. Mark is a conservationist. You don't just take the ocean's gifts — you give something

world's great ocean cultures.

back to the ecosystem that made the whole experience possible.

THE TEACHER

Mark Healey and the North Shore.

Mark Healey

NORTH SHORE, OAHU
BWRAG CERTIFIED
WSL SAFETY EXPERT

Mark Healey grew up on the North Shore and has spent his career there — surfing the biggest waves in the world, building an expertise in ocean safety that is unmatched, and becoming one of the founding voices of the Big Wave Risk Assessment Group (BWRAG), the organization the World Surf League calls when it needs safety protocols for big wave events. When Jaws and Nazaré and Mavericks run their biggest days, the safety infrastructure that keeps professional surfers alive is built on frameworks that Mark helped create.

He is also a world-class freediver and conservationist — someone who understands the ocean not just as a sporting arena but as an ecosystem with its own logic, its own fragility, and its own demands on the people who enter it. His approach to teaching is built around the same principles he applies to big wave surfing: accurate assessment, honest preparation, and the ability to operate calmly when the situation is genuinely serious.

The WSL doesn't call just anyone for safety expertise. They call Mark because he has been in situations that most people can't imagine and has developed systems for surviving them. That accumulated knowledge — of what the ocean does when it gets big, and what the human nervous system does in response — is what he brings to every session of this immersion.

CERTIFICATION	ROLE

BIG WAVE SURFER
OCEAN SAFETY EXPERT
FREEDIVER
CONSERVATIONIST
YETI AMBASSADOR

BWRAG — Big Wave Risk Assessment Group

WSL safety expertise · big wave events globally

DISCIPLINES

Big wave surfing, freediving, ocean safety

BASE

North Shore, Oahu · lifelong

What the training looks like

The curriculum is built around progressive ocean exposure. It begins in calmer water with foundational ocean safety skills and builds, over 10 days, to genuine big-water experience. Every session starts with a briefing: current conditions, swell size and direction, wind, water temperature, and the specific hazards of that day's location. You learn to read this information yourself — from the beach, before you ever enter the water.

Hold-down training is the centerpiece of the physical curriculum. A hold-down is what happens when a wave breaks on you and you are driven underwater, held down by the white water, unable to surface until the energy dissipates. Professional big wave surfers are routinely held down for 10–20 seconds by single waves; two-wave hold-downs can last 30–40 seconds. The panic response — the desperate thrashing that burns oxygen and causes drowning — is the thing that kills people. Hold-down training teaches you to suppress that response: to relax your body, protect your head, and wait for the ocean to release you. This is practiced in progressively challenging conditions over the 10 days.

Freediving sessions are built around breath extension — learning to extend your comfortable breath-hold from the typical 60 seconds to 2–3 minutes through relaxation, technique, and controlled breathing. This is not a diving certification course. It is a tool for building a longer and calmer window underwater. Which is the tool you need when the ocean puts you there involuntarily.

> **On reading the ocean:** Mark's first teaching on Day 1 is not about swimming or surfing. It is about observation. He will stand on the beach at Waimea Bay and ask you what you see. Then he will tell you what is actually happening: where the current is running, where it's accelerating, where the water is going, what the wave shape tells you about the bottom, what the wind is doing to the surface. Learning to read the ocean is learning a language. The 10 days are a crash course in fluency.

THE ITINERARY · DAYS 1–6

Learning to read the water.

The first six days build the foundation: ocean reading, hold-down training, freediving, and paddling in progressively challenging conditions. By Day 6 you will be in open water that you could not have safely entered on Day 1. The progression is deliberate. The ocean does not respect people who skip steps.

01

ARRIVAL

North Shore

NO TRAINING
BEACH WALK
GROUP DINNER
EARLY SLEEP

ORIENTATION

Arrive. Walk the beach. Understand what you signed up for.

Transfer from Honolulu International Airport to accommodation on the North Shore — a house in Hale'iwa, walking distance from the water. Drop gear. Walk to Waimea Bay before the group dinner: stand at the shore and look out. If the swell is running, you will feel it before you see it — the ground vibrating with the impact of 30-foot waves hitting the sand. If the ocean is flat, you will see only a deceptive calm that the next three days will complicate. Group dinner at a Hale'iwa restaurant. Sleep at 9:00pm. First session is 6:00am.

02

OCEAN READING

See First

BEACH CLASSROOM
WATER ENTRY
CURRENT NAVIGATION

FOUNDATION

Mark's first lesson: stand on the beach and tell me what you see. Then he tells you what's actually there.

Morning: beach classroom at Waimea Bay. Mark walks the group through ocean reading — swell direction and period, wave shape and bottom contour, rip current identification, wind effect on surface. This is not theory. He points at what's in front of you and explains exactly what it means and what it will do in the next 30 seconds. You will watch a wave break and he will have described it ten seconds before it happened. The group begins to see the ocean rather than just look at it.

Afternoon: first water entry — calm bay conditions if available, or a protected beach near Hale'iwa. Rip current navigation exercises: how to identify a rip, how to use it to exit the surf zone quickly, how to swim out of it laterally rather than fighting it. The rip current is not your enemy if you understand it. It is a conveyor belt — moving you somewhere specific. The skill is knowing where it goes.

06:00–09:00
Ocean Reading
Beach classroom, swell, rips, current

14:00–17:00
Water Entry + Rips
First swim, current navigation

EVENING
Debrief
What was seen, what was missed

03

HOLD-DOWN

Underwater

AM: POOL TRAINING
PM: OPEN WATER
BREATH WORK

CORE SKILL

The hold-down training begins. The panic response is the thing to train out.

Morning: hold-down training begins in a pool — controlled environment, Mark present, no ocean variables. The exercise: go underwater, relax completely, extend your breath-hold through stillness rather than effort. This is counterintuitive. When oxygen is running low the body's impulse is to thrash. The training teaches you to override that impulse: to slow heart rate, relax muscles, and trust that the surface will be there when the energy releases. This is the central skill of ocean safety and it is built one breath-hold at a time.

Afternoon: first open-water hold-down practice in the whitewash of a small shore break — actual wave energy, but manageable. Mark is in the water throughout. The goal is not impressive — it is honest: relax when something pushes you down, and come up when it lets you go. Don't fight it. That instruction sounds simple. In the water, with white foam and pressure, it requires practice.

06:00–08:00
Pool Hold-Down Training
Breath extension, panic suppression

14:00–17:00
Shore Break Practice
Real wave energy, whitewash holds

EVENING
Breath Protocol Review
Diaphragmatic breathing, CO2 tables

04

WAIMEA BAY

The Classroom

AM: SHORE STUDY
PM: BAY SWIM
PIPELINE OBSERVATION

ENCOUNTER

Waimea Bay — where Eddie Aikau surfed. You read it from shore, then you swim it.

Morning: extended shore session at Waimea Bay with Mark. He describes the history — Eddie Aikau, the Eddie Invitational (the competition that only runs when faces are 20 feet or bigger), the 1978 Hokule'a incident when Eddie paddled into the ocean and never came back. He describes the mechanics of Waimea: how the bay funnels swell, why the wave breaks where it does, what happens to swimmers caught on the inside when a set comes. The shore education is the safety education.

Afternoon: bay swim — conditions permitting and Mark's assessment of safety. If the bay is flat or small, you swim the full bay. If it is running, you study from shore and swim a safer adjacent break. The ocean decides the curriculum. That is the lesson. Evening: drive along the coast to Pipeline and study from shore — the wave shape, the reef, the way it throws. You will never unsee what Pipeline looks like when it's running.

06:00–09:00
Waimea Shore Study
History, mechanics, decision-making

14:00–17:00
Bay Swim
Conditions-dependent · Mark in water

EVENING
Pipeline Shore Study
The reef, the throw, the consequence

05

FREEDIVING

Breath Extension

AM: TECHNIQUE
PM: OPEN WATER
OCEAN FLOOR

DEPTH

Freediving is not about going deep. It's about being comfortable down there.

Two-session freediving day. Morning: technique — the duck dive, finning mechanics, equalization, the freefall (the point below 10 meters where the body becomes negatively buoyant and sinks without effort). Theory of mammalian diving reflex: the physiological slowdown the body executes automatically when the face hits cold water. How to encourage it rather than fight it. The goal for the 10 days is a comfortable 2-minute breath-hold at the surface and a comfortable 10-meter dive.

Afternoon: freediving session in a protected North Shore bay — clear water over sand and reef. Following the seafloor 6–8 meters down, hovering without moving, coming up slowly. The ocean floor at this depth on the North Shore is extraordinary: reef architecture, fish, the filtered light from the surface. The quietness of it — the total removal of land noise — is something that does not fully translate into words.

06:00–09:00
Freediving Theory
Breath technique, mammalian dive reflex

14:00–17:00
Open Water Dives
Protected bay · 6–10m target depth

EVENING
Rest + Recovery
The body adapts overnight

06

SWELL DAY

Big Water

MARK DECIDES
CONDITIONS-BASED
FULL OCEAN DAY

ADVENTURE

Big swell day. Mark reads the morning report and makes the call. You follow his lead.

Day 6 is a full ocean day structured around whatever conditions present. If a significant swell is running — the North Shore in winter reliably produces multiple large swells per two-week window — this is the day to observe it up close. Mark positions the group at the safest vantage points, walks the shore with you, and explains in real time what the ocean is doing and why. If conditions allow safe water entry at a protected break while the main spots are running, you enter. If they don't, you don't. The decision is not yours. This is the most important thing Mark teaches: knowing when not to go in.

The most instructive thing about being on the North Shore during a large swell is the sound. The impact of a 25-foot wave breaking on shallow reef is physical — you feel it in your chest before you hear it, and the white water runs for two hundred meters. Nothing prepares you for the scale until you're standing next to it. The scale is the education.

> **The cardinal rule:** Mark will repeat this every day in varying forms: the ocean is not trying to kill you. It is indifferent. It does not know you are there. Everything that happens is physics, not malice. Understanding the physics — and respecting the indifference — is what keeps people alive. Ego is what gets people hurt on the North Shore. Its absence is the entire curriculum.

THE ITINERARY · DAYS 7–10

Waterman skills.

The second half integrates everything — paddling, ocean reading, hold-down confidence, freediving — into the full waterman skillset. Day 9 is the conservation day. Day 10 is the final open-water assessment. You leave the North Shore as someone who understands the ocean in a way you did not when you arrived.

07

REST DAY

Hale'iwa

NO WATER TRAINING
TOWN + CULTURE
SUNSET AT WAIMEA

REST + CULTURE

Rest day. The North Shore is a place and a culture — today you live in it.

No training. Hale'iwa town — the historic center of North Shore culture: the old bridge, the shave ice, the surf shops that have been here since the 1970s. The photo history of surfing on the walls of buildings and restaurants — from Duke Kahanamoku to Eddie Aikau to the current generation. The North Shore is not just a place to surf. It is where surfing became a serious thing. Walk slowly. Eat well. Talk to people. Rest.

Sunset at Waimea Bay as a group. No agenda. The bay in evening light when the day's swell has settled is one of the most beautiful places in the world. You will have been in that water this week. That changes how it looks.

> **Active recovery:** After six days of ocean training, the body needs a full day. This is not negotiable. The second half of the week is physically more demanding than the first. Sleep long tonight.

08

PADDLING

Waterman Skills

AM: PADDLE TRAINING
PM: OPEN OCEAN
SWELL READING

INTEGRATION

Paddling is how watermen move. On a board, on a SUP, swimming — it is all the same skill.

Morning: longboard and SUP paddling session — proper paddling mechanics (most people paddle with their arms when the power should come from the torso and hips), how to position on a board for maximum efficiency, how to read a building swell and paddle over it before it breaks. Mark demonstrates what happens when you get the timing wrong, and what happens when you get it right. The difference is everything.

Afternoon: extended open-ocean swim — 1km ocean channel between two North Shore points, reading current and adjusting line throughout. Mark swims with the group. This is the most physically demanding session of the week and also the most satisfying: an hour in the open ocean, out of your depth, moving under your own power, and understanding where you are.

06:00–09:00
Board Paddling
Technique, swell timing, positioning

14:00–17:00
Open Ocean Swim
1km channel crossing · Mark in water

EVENING
Debrief + Night Sky
The North Shore night sky over the Pacific

09

SERVICE DAY

Reef Cleanup

FULL DAY
CONSERVATION
OCEAN GIVING BACK

SERVICE + CONSERVATION

The reef that made all of this possible. Give something back to it.

Full-day ocean conservation and reef cleanup with a local Hawaiian organization that Mark has supported for years. The North Shore's reef systems — the same reefs that create the waves at Pipeline, Waimea, and Sunset — are under documented stress from warming ocean temperatures, fishing practices, and physical damage from marine debris. The cleanup is real work: freediving to collect debris from reef structures, surface collection in the channel, documentation of reef condition.

Mark's conservation work is not separate from his surfing or his safety expertise — it is the same relationship to the ocean, expressed differently. To be a waterman means to care about the health of the water. Spending a day doing physical conservation work deepens that relationship in a way that watching nature documentaries cannot. You are not observing — you are participating.

WHY CONSERVATION IS NOT OPTIONAL

The ocean is a system. You cannot take from it indefinitely without contributing to it.

Mark Healey has been a vocal conservationist alongside his big wave career because he understands that the North Shore's waves are inseparable from the reef that creates them, and the reef is inseparable from the ocean's health. The Eddie Invitational — the contest that only runs when Waimea is 20 feet — has raised significant funds for Hawaiian ocean conservation. The tradition of the waterman includes stewardship. Joining a reef cleanup on Day 9 is not a gesture. It is the completion of the week's education about what it means to be in genuine relationship with the ocean.

10

FINAL DAY

Full Assessment

AM: FINAL SESSION
MARK'S ASSESSMENT
AFTERNOON DEPART

CLOSING

The final session. Mark tells you what he saw. What changed.

Final morning session: full conditions-based ocean session — conditions permitting, the group enters the water at the most challenging break they've successfully navigated during the week. Hold-down confidence. Current reading. Open swimming. The skills integrated. Mark watches. He has been watching for 10 days and he will tell each person specifically what changed, what still needs work, and what to do next.

Group debrief at the beach: not a recap, but a conversation about what the ocean taught. What you know now about your own nervous system that you didn't know before. What composure looks like when it's not a metaphor but a physical practice. Afternoon departure from Honolulu International.

06:00–09:00
Final Ocean Session
Full integration · Mark's final assessment

10:00
Beach Debrief
Individual feedback · what changed

AFTERNOON
Depart
Honolulu International · afternoon flights

LOGISTICS · WHAT'S INCLUDED · HOW TO APPLY

Everything you need to know.

LOCATION

North Shore, Oahu, Hawaii

Base: Hale'iwa · 1hr from Honolulu International (HNL)

DURATION

10 Days

Arrive Day 1 evening · Depart Day 10 afternoon

GROUP SIZE

8 spots

Mark is in the water with you every session. Small is mandatory.

INVESTMENT

$3,200

All-inclusive except international flights and travel insurance.

PREREQUISITE

Comfortable swimmer

Must be able to swim 500m comfortably in open water. No surfing experience required.

SEASON

November — February

North Shore swell season. The only time this immersion runs.

TRAINING SCHEDULE

Ocean daily · 6:00am

Morning and afternoon sessions. Conditions dictate exact structure every day.

APPLY

apply@bridgethegap.com

Include swim background and current fitness level. Response within 48 hours.

What's included

- **All ocean training sessions**
  10 days with Mark Healey. All safety equipment provided. Mark in the water every session.
- **Accommodation**
  House on the North Shore in Hale'iwa. Walking distance to water.
- **Daily meals**
- **Hold-down training**

Breakfast and post-session recovery food. Group dinners together. Local Hawaiian food throughout.

Pool and open water. The central curriculum. Progressive over 10 days.

- **Freediving sessions**
  Days 5 and integration days. Breath extension, open-water dives to 10m target depth.
- **Waimea Bay session**
  Day 4. Shore education and water entry conditions-permitting with Mark.
- **Pipeline shore study**
  Day 4 evening. The most famous wave in the world, studied with the person the WSL calls for safety.
- **1km open ocean channel swim**
  Day 8. The most demanding physical session of the week. Mark in the water throughout.
- **Reef conservation day**
  Day 9 — full day with local Hawaiian conservation organization. Freedive reef cleanup.
- **All water safety equipment**
  Fins, masks, safety vests, leashes, boards. Everything needed for every session.
- **BWRAG ocean safety curriculum**
  Mark's certified framework — the same protocols used at professional big wave events.
- **Airport transfers**
  Day 1 pickup and Day 10 drop-off at Honolulu International (HNL).

What to bring

Boardshorts and rash guard — multiple pairs, you will be wet most of the day. Wetsuit top recommended for winter water temperatures (24–25°C). Reef-safe sunscreen only — non-negotiable on a conservation-focused program. Water shoes for reef entry. Everything else is provided.

What is not included

Flights to Honolulu (HNL). Travel insurance — required, must include ocean sports coverage. Personal spending. The immersion runs only during North Shore swell season (November–February). The ocean determines exact session locations and entry decisions every day.

THE GAP · MICRO IMMERSION SERIES · OCEAN · NORTH SHORE, HAWAII

8 spots. North Shore. Are you in?

You don't need to be a surfer. You need to be a strong swimmer and willing to enter water that is larger than you. The ocean will take care of the curriculum. Mark will keep you alive while it does.

REGISTER INTEREST / APPLY
apply@bridgethegap.com

PROGRAM WEBSITE
bridgethegap.com

THE GAP

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